undertook extensive fieldwork in Balochistan in 2009 both agreed that RAW had provided financial support, though there was no definitive evidence that its assistance extended to providing weapons or training to Baloch separatists.[60] Minor though support may have been, however, Baloch separatism was and remains a neuralgic issue for Pakistan. So too is India's overall presence in Afghanistan. As its economic and diplomatic footprint there grew, the Taliban's utility as an instrument to secure Pakistan's interests increased.

This expansion of Indian influence coincided with increasing uncertainty about US staying power in Afghanistan. In summer 2005 Washington announced that it would hand over control of the Afghan mission to NATO, and later said that it would withdraw more than 1,000 troops. Because of the escalating insurgency the order was reversed, but Lt. Gen. David Barno (Retd), who had been the US commander in Afghanistan at the time, testified two years later that the message sent by the initial order caused 'both friends and enemies to re-calculate their options—with a view toward the US no longer being a lead actor in Afghanistan.' He specified that in mid-2005 Pakistan 're-calculated its position vis-à-vis Afghanistan in light of concerns for a diminished and less aggressive U.S. presence.'[61] Former US Deputy Secretary of State Richard Armitage offered a similar assessment, suggesting that the ISI became more heavily involved in Afghanistan in late 2005–early 2006.[62] A trove of US military field reports from Afghanistan in 2004–2009 were leaked in 2010 and reconfirmed the already common assessment that the ISI was abetting, and at times possibly guiding, militants fighting Coalition forces in Afghanistan. This reportedly included all manner of support, including direct assistance to the Taliban with organizing military offensives.[63] In other words, just when Musharraf's regime was reducing the tempo of operations in Indian-administered Kashmir, the ISI was simultaneously expanding support to insurgents in Afghanistan. Yet its alliance with America also forced Pakistan to take steps against some militants, for which its military and citizenry paid in blood.

The development of the insurgency in Pakistan that sprang forth from the Tribal Areas is worthy of its own book-length study. Briefly stated, the Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan [TTP], a consortium of pro-Taliban tribal militants that officially united in 2007 and spearheaded the insurgency,